

MAID EZ CLEANING

Business Starter Tips

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Columbia, Missouri 65202

Getting Started in the Cleaning Business

Congratulations on starting your cleaning business journey! I've been cleaning homes and businesses in Columbia, Missouri since 2017, and I've learned a lot along the way. These tips come from real experience - the successes and the mistakes. I hope they help you build a thriving business.

The Fundamentals

1 Get Your Business Legal

Before you clean your first home, make sure your business is properly registered. In Missouri, this means:

- Register your business name with the Secretary of State
- Get an EIN from the IRS (it's free!)
- Check if your city/county requires a business license
- Consider forming an LLC to protect your personal assets

2 Insurance is Non-Negotiable

General liability insurance protects you if something gets damaged or someone gets hurt. It's not expensive - often \$500-800/year - and it's essential. Some clients won't hire you without proof of insurance.

3 Price for Profit, Not Just to Get the Job

This is the #1 mistake new cleaners make. Here's my formula:

- Calculate your hourly labor cost (including taxes)
- Add supply costs per job (\$5-10)
- Add overhead (10% of revenue)
- Add your desired profit margin (30-50%)

Example: If labor is \$20/hr for 3 hours = \$60, plus \$8 supplies, plus 10% overhead = \$7.50, you need to charge at least \$110 just to break even. Add 40% profit = \$154 for a 3-hour clean.

4 Use Professional Systems from Day One

The checklists and templates in this kit aren't just for show - they:

- Ensure consistent quality on every job
- Show clients you're professional (not just "someone who cleans")
- Help you train employees when you expand
- Protect you from "you missed this" complaints

Getting Clients

5 Start with Your Network

Your first clients are probably people you already know. Post on Facebook, tell your friends and family, and offer a referral discount. My first 5 clients were all friends of friends.

6 Facebook is Your Best Friend

Join local community groups and offer your services. Post before/after photos (with permission). Respond quickly to comments and messages. Be helpful, not pushy.

7 Get Reviews Early

After your first few jobs, ask happy clients for Google reviews. Reviews are social proof that helps future clients trust you. Make it easy - send them a direct link to your Google Business profile.

Running the Business

8 Track Everything

From day one, track:

- Income and expenses (use QuickBooks Self-Employed or a simple spreadsheet)
- Mileage (deductible at \$0.67/mile in 2024)
- Client contact info and preferences
- Which products work best for which jobs

9 Set Boundaries

Decide your service area and stick to it. Don't take jobs that are too far away - the drive time kills your hourly rate. Decide your hours and don't answer calls at 10 PM. This is a business, not a 24/7 emergency service (unless you want it to be).

10 Communicate Clearly

Send confirmation texts the day before. Let clients know when you're running late. Follow up after the first clean to make sure they're happy. Good communication turns one-time clients into regulars.

Growing Your Business

When to Hire Help

Consider hiring when you're consistently booked 30+ hours a week and turning down work. Start with an independent contractor (1099) before taking on the responsibility of a W-2 employee. Use the Hiring Checklist in this kit when you're ready.

Focus on Recurring Revenue

One-time cleans are nice, but recurring clients are the foundation of a stable business. Offer a discount for weekly or bi-weekly service. A client who pays \$120 every two weeks is worth \$3,120/year.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

Don't Undercharge to Compete

There's always someone cheaper. Compete on quality and reliability, not price. Clients who choose based on price alone are often the hardest to please.

Don't Skip the Walkthrough

Always do an in-person walkthrough before giving a quote for a new client. Photos don't show everything, and you don't want surprises that eat into your profit.

Don't Take Every Client

If someone seems difficult during the initial conversation, they'll probably be difficult as a client. It's okay to say "I'm not the right fit for your needs."

Your First Week Checklist

Before Your First Job:

- Register your business name
- Get liability insurance
- Set up a business bank account
- Buy supplies using the Shopping List in this kit
- Customize the checklists with your business info
- Set up a simple booking system (even just a calendar)
- Create a Google Business profile
- Post on social media that you're open for business

Remember: Every successful cleaning business started with one client and one job. Don't wait until everything is perfect - start with what you have, learn as you go, and keep improving. You've got this!

